

Presentation/MSE:

MSE Domain	Key Descriptors	Standard Clinical Note Phrasing Example
Appearance & Behavior	Well-groomed, disheveled, unkempt, attire appropriate/inappropriate, eye contact (appropriate, poor, fleeting), posture, psychomotor agitation/retardation, cooperative, guarded, hostile	<i>Client presented as well-groomed, neatly dressed, and cooperative with calm psychomotor activity and appropriate eye contact.</i>
Speech	Rate (normal, rapid, slow, pressured), volume (soft, loud, normal), tone (clear, monotone, slurred, dysarthric), latency	<i>Speech was clear, fluent, and articulate with normal rate, volume, and latency.</i>
Mood (Subjective)	Client's self-reported emotional state in quotes (e.g., "good," "anxious," "depressed," "stressed," "fine," "hopeless")	<i>Mood reported as "anxious and overwhelmed."</i>
Affect (Objective)	Range (full/broad, restricted, blunted, flat, labile), quality (euthymic, dysphoric, irritable, euphoric), congruency (congruent/incongruent with mood)	<i>Observed affect was euthymic, full-range, and fully congruent with reported mood.</i>
Thought Process	Organization & flow: linear, logical, goal-directed, circumstantial, tangential, flight of ideas, loose associations, word salad	<i>Thought process was linear, logical, and goal-directed.</i>
Thought Content	Preoccupations, safety risk (denied/active SI/HI, NSSI urges), delusions, paranoia, obsessions, phobias	<i>Thought content was free of delusions or preoccupations; denied current suicidal or homicidal ideation.</i>
Perception	Sensory disturbances: auditory/visual/tactile/olfactory hallucinations, illusions, depersonalization, derealization	<i>No auditory or visual perceptual disturbances were reported or observed.</i>
Cognition & Sensorium	Level of consciousness (alert, lethargic), orientation (Person, Place, Time, Situation: O x 4), attention, concentration, gross memory	<i>Client was alert and oriented x 4 with gross memory and sustained attention intact.</i>
Insight & Judgment	Insight: Awareness of mental health/condition (good, fair, poor). Judgment: Quality of decision-making and safety	<i>Insight into current stressors and judgment regarding treatment and personal safety appeared good.</i>

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	choices (sound, fair, impaired).	

Example:

“Client presented as neatly dressed but visibly tense, demonstrating frequent fidgeting and fleeting eye contact. Speech was rapid and elevated in tone. Mood reported as overwhelmed with an anxious, hypervigilant affect. Thought process was circumstantial with preoccupations regarding health concerns, though no safety concerns or delusions were present. No perceptual disturbances noted. Cognition intact. Insight and judgment appeared good.”